Cut the Rope: how players are receiving the game

Player sentiment before and after the 4.0 migration update: Jan–Aug 2026 (v3.x) vs Sep–Oct 2026 (v4.x). Sources: Play Console and Sensor Tower ratings, 6,450 store reviews, 3,300 YouTube comments. Data as of 2 Nov 2026.

4.52 → 4.24
Google Play rating, all raters (Play Console, 30-day avg)

4.68 → 4.50
App Store rating, all raters (Sensor Tower, new ratings)

23% → 60%
Share of negative written reviews (Play + iOS)

3% → 41%
Reviews saying "the update ruined it / bring back the old one"

Executive summary

- **The 4.0 migration is the most significant sentiment event of the year, and it is negative.** Both stores were flat from January to August. The Google Play rating then fell from 4.52 to 4.24 (a 12-month low of 4.16 in mid-October). The App Store rating fell from 4.68 to 4.50 in a single step during the 15–22 Sep iOS rollout. Both are still above 4★. A small recovery started after 4.3.0 (26 Oct).
- **The update caused it.** In the same weeks of the Android partial rollout, Play reviewers on v3.x averaged 4.1★ and those on v4.x 2.8★. On iOS the drop lines up with the rollout dates exactly.
- **Before the update, players were fond of the game but unhappy about ads.** 59% of reviews praised it as fun or relaxing and 20% mentioned childhood. Ad volume was the main complaint (27%).
- **After the update, the complaint moved from "too many ads" to "you changed the game I loved".** The new 4.x complaints are: **no level select or replay** (1% → 17%), **lives / limited attempts** (1% → 14%), **art that looks AI-made** (0% → 9%), **"pay-to-play" / greed** (2% → 6%) and **UI clutter and pop-ups** (1% → 5%). Praise for fun halved (59% → 28%).
- **Ad complaints fell** (27% → 19%). That fits fewer interstitials per DAU after the switch to MAX (3.11 → 2.29) and the 2-day ad-free period for migrated players. The monetization grievance has moved to lives and coins instead.
- **YouTube amplifies the story.** Four update videos have about 880k views. Weighted by upvotes, the themes are "update ruined it" (37%), AI art (27%), blame on ZeptoLab as "corporate greed" (17%) and lives (11%). A widely liked claim says the icon carries a Gemini watermark. That icon came from an old test run and is not the live one, but the claim is spreading as fact.
- **It is not only veterans.** Reviews with and without a "long-time player" signal are equally negative (62% vs 59%). **Market split:** the US Play rating held steady (4.02 → 4.01), but the US App Store rating dropped like everywhere else (4.71 → 4.53).

What is driving the shift, by impact

#	Driver	Evidence	Status internally
1	Lives / limited attempts on a trial-and-error puzzle	14% of v4 reviews; 11% of YouTube upvote weight; top comment (1.3k likes): “like adding lives to Super Meat Boy”	No decision found
2	No level select / replay; star-gated progression in 3-level stages	17% of v4 reviews; support ticket from a parent who replayed levels with their child	Raised internally, unanswered
3	Art perceived as AI-generated ("AI slop", "Cut the AI"); old test icon with watermark circulating	9% of reviews; 27% of YouTube upvote weight	Art team suggested a new hand-made icon; not scheduled
4	"Pay-to-play" perception: coins, Play Pass, pop-ups, events you can’t opt out of	6% of reviews, plus UI and pop-up complaints (5%)	4.4.0 adds banners and a loss offer, which may make this worse

#	Driver	Evidence	Status internally
5	End-of-content black screen (level 190/191), migration losses	3–4% of reviews	Planned for 4.4.0

1. Sources and method

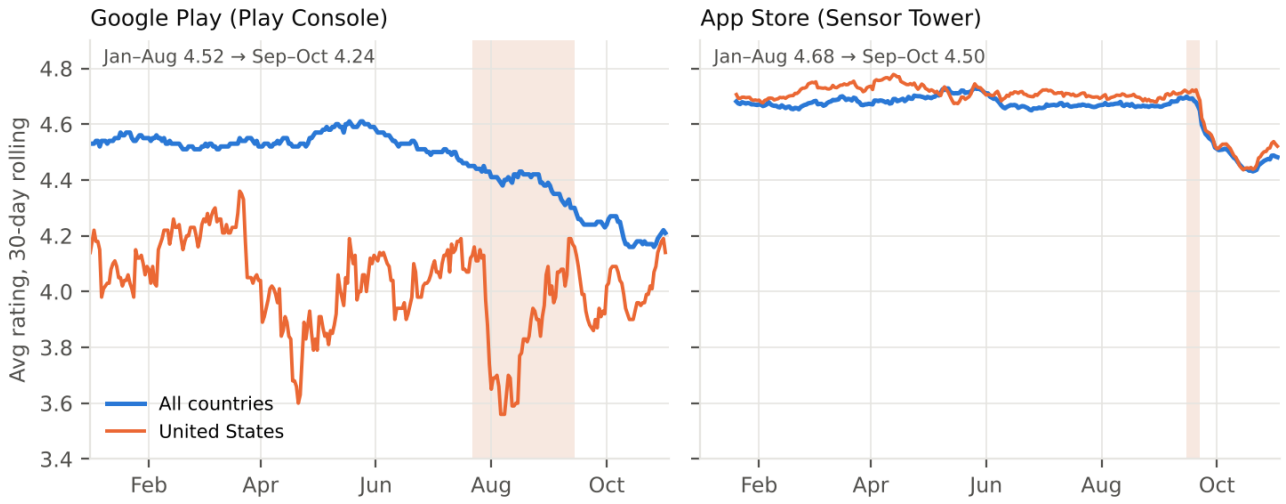
Source	What	Volume (Jan 1 – Nov 2, 2026)
Google Play Console	Average rating, 30-day rolling, all countries and US, with release notes	Daily
Sensor Tower (App Store)	New ratings per day and country (111 countries); all App Store reviews with version	28,600 new ratings; 1,108 reviews
Google Play reviews	All written reviews in 11 languages, with app version	5,344 reviews
YouTube	157 videos about the game in 2026; comments from the 15 most relevant (incl. both reference videos)	3,276 comments (2,462 labelled)
Internal (Slack)	#ctr-unity-dev, -release, -analytics, #evergreen-studio-leads, support	Rollout dates, issues, roadmap

Periods. A = Jan–Aug and B = Sep–Oct, as requested. The Android partial rollout ran 22 Jul–15 Sep (1% → 100%) and iOS ran 15–22 Sep, so August is a mixed month on Android. As a check, Play reviewers on v3.x and v4.x are compared within the same weeks, using the app version attached to each review.

Coding. A 26-code topic list was built from a stratified sample of 300 reviews (Sonnet). Every review and comment of at least 15 characters was then labelled for topics, polarity, sentiment, mention of the update and long-time-player signal (Haiku: 5,166 reviews and 2,462 comments). An independent check of 60 random labels (Sonnet) found sentiment and update mention 100% correct and topic precision/recall 96%/95%, with no bias between periods. Differences called significant pass a two-proportion z-test at $p<0.01$.

Limitations. Topic shares come from *written* reviews, and angry players are over-represented there; the size of the effect is taken from the all-rater ratings instead. Reddit and Discord are not included in this version. Confluence design docs were not readable, so 4.x mechanics come from Slack and player descriptions. YouTube transcripts were blocked, so videos are analysed through their comments. One review containing a possible safeguarding disclosure was excluded and flagged separately.

2. Ratings: a step down with the rollout



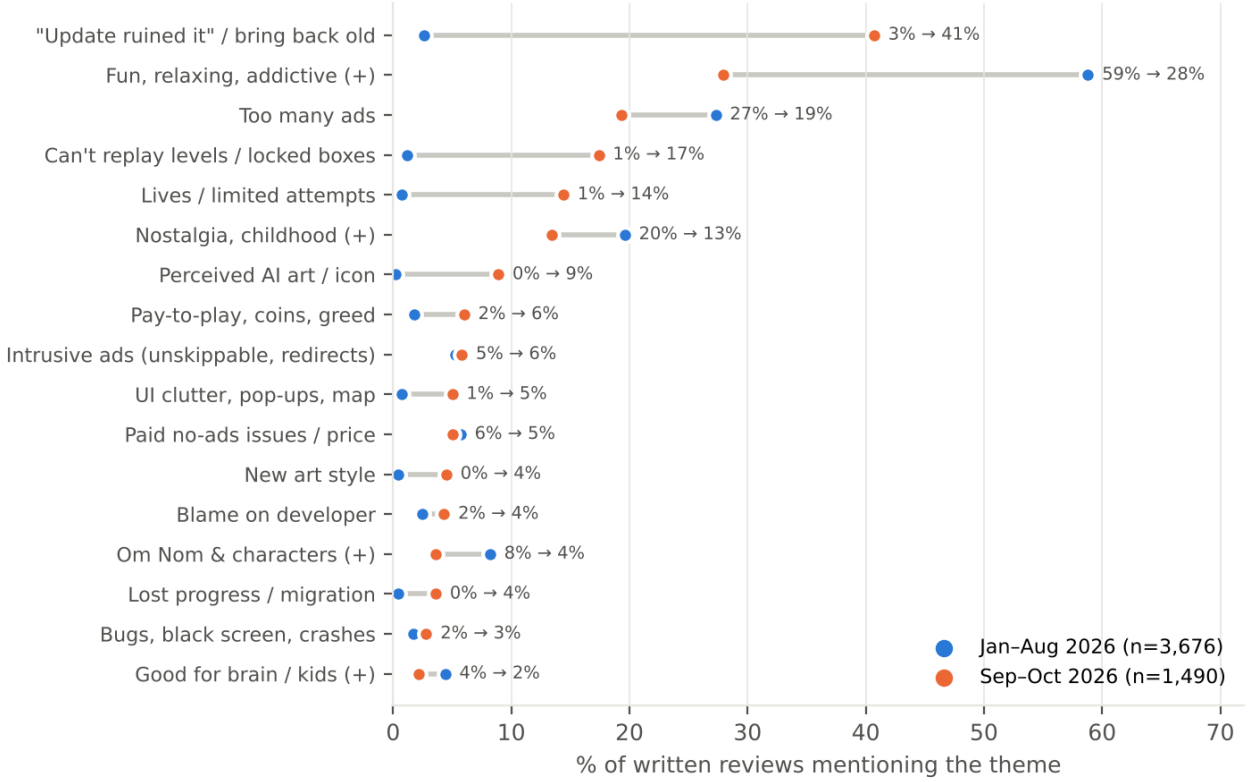
Average rating as a 30-day rolling average. Google Play: Play Console. App Store: Sensor Tower new ratings (negative "rating removal" adjustments excluded). Shaded: rollout windows.

	Jan–Aug	Sep–Oct	Low point	Latest (late Oct / early Nov)
Google Play – all countries	4.52	**4.24**	4.16 (13 Oct)	4.21–4.22 after 4.3.0
Google Play – US	4.02	4.01	3.56 (6 Aug)	4.14

	Jan–Aug	Sep–Oct	Low point	Latest (late Oct / early Nov)
App Store – all countries	4.68	**4.50**	4.43 (20 Oct)	4.54 (26 Oct–2 Nov)
App Store – US	4.71	**4.53**	4.44 (15 Oct)	4.61 (26 Oct–2 Nov)
Written reviews – Google Play	4.26	2.91		vocal minority, see §3
Written reviews – App Store	3.33	2.35		vocal minority, see §3

- **Google Play** lost about 0.3★, and the decline follows the rollout steps: 4.42 at 30% (24 Aug), 4.28 at 100% (15 Sep), 4.16 by mid-October. The **US held steady**. It is volatile anyway: it fell to 3.6 in April with no release. Its one sharp dip (4.13 → 3.56, 22 Jul–6 Aug) came during the 1–5% stage. Slack describes that stage as excluding the US, while the Console notes say "171 countries". Worth checking.
- **App Store** was flat at about 4.67 for eight months, then dropped about 0.2★ within a week of the 15–22 Sep rollout, **in the US as much as elsewhere**. Rating volume rose at the same time (2.7k new ratings in August, 4.4k in October). More people were moved to rate, and they rated lower.
- **Since 4.3.0** (Super Om Nom and Sweet Challenge back, 26 Oct) both stores are recovering slightly: iOS 4.54 and Play 4.22. It is too early to call this a trend.
- **Written reviews** show the same timing at much larger amplitude: Play 4.26 → 2.91, 1★ share 13% → 44%; iOS 3.33 → 2.35, 1★ share 30% → 55%. They are the right place to learn *why*, not *how much*.

3. What players praise and what they criticise



Share of written reviews (Google Play + App Store) mentioning each theme. Blue = Jan–Aug, orange = Sep–Oct. A review can mention up to 4 themes.

What players praise (the stable core)

- **The core puzzle is loved.** "Fun, relaxing, addictive" was the most common theme before the update (59%). Players praise short levels, satisfying physics and the escalating difficulty.
- **Nostalgia is a huge asset.** 20% of pre-update reviews mention childhood ("I played it at 5", "the theme of my 7th birthday party"). After the update the same feeling turns into grief: "you ruined my childhood game".
- **Om Nom and the classic art** (8%), and the game being **good for kids and the brain** (4%). Parents are a visible segment, and **offline play** (flights, kids) is valued.

  “When I was a kid, I loved this game. As I became older, the view never changed!!” — Play, Mar 2026, 5★

  “Excellent game! It gets harder as you go, but it’s really fun. I love the music, the look and the very well-designed mechanics.” — Play, Mar 2026, 5★, translated from Spanish

What players criticise, Jan–Aug (v3.x)

- **Ad volume** (27%): an interstitial after every level or retry, "more ads than gameplay". Players turn off wifi as a workaround.
- **Intrusive ads** (5%): hard-to-find close buttons, redirects to the store, long unskippable ads.
- **Paid no-ads problems** (6%): "I paid and still get ads" (rewarded ads, ads for other games), the $9.99 price, subscription confusion. This is the top theme on iOS.

  “The amount of ads is horrendous. Every time you wanna retry a level? Ad. You beat a level? Ad. You die? AD!” — App Store, Feb 2026, 1★

  “This app is an ad-watching simulator with a few touches of gameplay in between.” — Play, Mar 2026, 1★, translated from Spanish

What players criticise, Sep–Oct (v4.x)

- **"The update ruined it / bring back the old version"** (41%). Many name no specific feature; they are reacting to the game no longer feeling like itself.
- **Can’t replay levels; locked boxes; must 3-star to progress; 3-level stages** (17%).

- **Lives / limited attempts / limited candy** (14%), seen as wrong for a trial-and-error puzzle and as a push to watch ads or pay.
- **Art that looks AI-made** (9%) and a **new art style** (5%). Only 4 store reviews mention Gemini or a watermark; the rest object to the look in general. **UI clutter and pop-ups** (5%): migrated players get every feature pop-up in their first session.
- **Pay-to-play / greed** (6%), **blame on the developer** (4%), **lost progress or purchases** (4%), **black screen at level 191** and changed physics (3%).

  “You can’t replay levels, there is a lives system, and if you move the bouncy pad to the other side of a conveyor and it hits the candy, it breaks?! They really ruined it.” — Play, Sep 2026, 3★

  “The new limited lives and pay to play mechanics take a once loved game and make it joyless.” — Play, Sep 2026, 1★

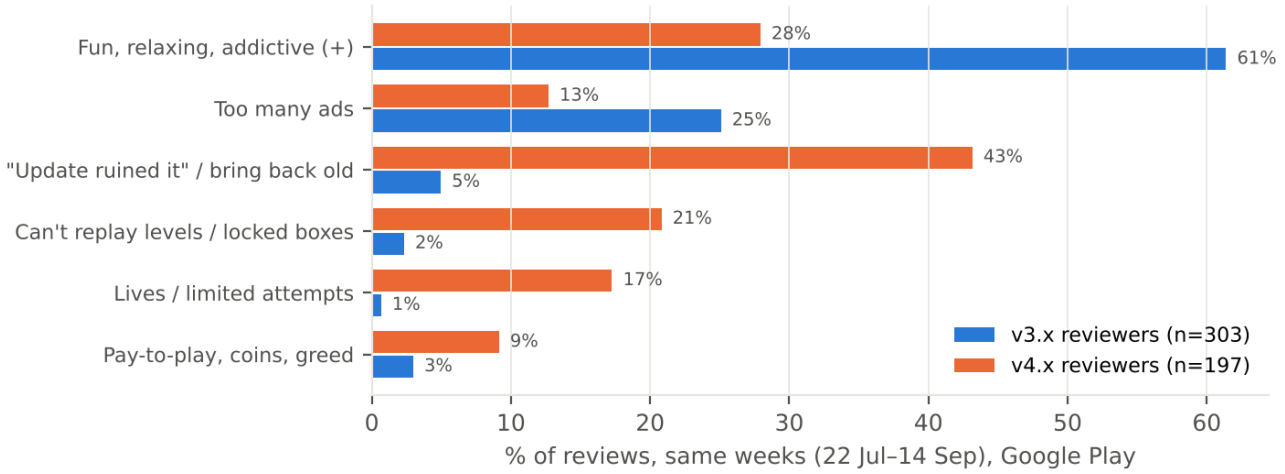
  “This game was great 10 years ago when I first played it. Now I had to go past 10 different pop-ups… Just let me play the damn game and stay out of my way.” — Play, Oct 2026, 1★

  “I kept this app only for flights on flight mode. But with the new update even that’s not possible anymore… the life system destroyed what was left of the game.” — Play, Oct 2026, 1★

  “Change it back. I liked the old style more. This game was so nostalgic to me. I was appalled to see the huge change when I opened the app.” — App Store, Sep 2026, 1★

4. What critically changed between the two versions

To separate the update from calendar effects (season, country mix, featuring), the chart compares Google Play reviewers on v3.x and v4.x **in the same weeks** of the partial rollout.



Change (written reviews)	Jan–Aug	Sep–Oct	Verdict
Negative overall sentiment	23%	60%	**Critical**, ×2.6
Praise for fun / relaxing	59%	28%	**Critical**: the core promise is no longer felt
"Update ruined it / bring back old"	3%	41%	**Critical**, new
Level access / replay / star gating	1%	17%	**Critical**, new, design-driven
Lives / limited attempts	1%	14%	**Critical**, new, design-driven
Art perceived as AI-generated	0%	9%	**High**: small in stores, dominant on YouTube
Pay-to-play / greed	2%	6%	**High**, rising
UI clutter / pop-ups	1%	5%	Medium
Lost progress / migration	0.4%	4%	Medium (bugs ticketed)
Too many ads	27%	19%	Improved (also crowded out by other topics)
Paid no-ads issues	6%	5%	Unchanged
Nostalgia (+)	20%	13%	Lower, and turning into grief

Who is upset? Not just veterans. Among Sep–Oct reviews, those signalling a long history with the game are 62% negative and the rest 59%. Review text cannot reliably isolate brand-new installs, so the internal view that new users like 4.x is better tested with retention data. On iOS the all-rater rating fell as much in the US as elsewhere, which argues against a purely "angry migrants" story.

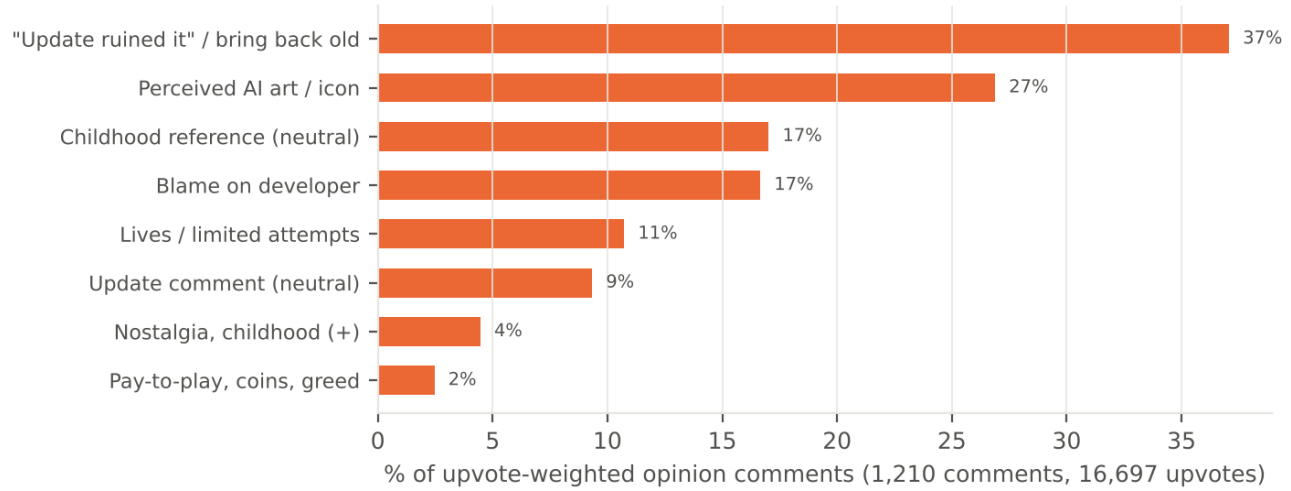
Early read on 4.3.0. Restoring Super Om Nom and Sweet Challenge coincides with a slight recovery in both stores (iOS 4.43 → 4.54, Play 4.16 → 4.22). The number of reviews saying "ruined" is not yet falling clearly.

5. YouTube: where the narrative is being written

YouTube reaches far more people than the stores. The update videos are almost uniformly negative: 71% of opinion comments are negative and 8% positive. Pre-update videos (cutscene evolutions, challenge runs) get warm, nostalgic comments.

Video	Channel	Published	Views	Comments
You Won’t Believe What Just Happened to Cut the Rope	SnipeSnap	7 Oct	571k	1.4k
Cut The Rope Is Being Replaced...	Cut the Rope Home	27 Sep	164k	973
Do NOT Download These Fake Cut the Rope Games...	SnipeSnap	29 Oct	116k	197

Video	Channel	Published	Views	Comments
Reviews Are In For The Horrible Cut The Rope Update	Cut the Rope Home	11 Oct	30k	302



Themes in opinion comments on the update videos, weighted by likes, so they reflect what the audience endorses.

- **"AI art" is the YouTube story.** The most-liked specific comment (1.5k likes) says the icon shows a Gemini watermark, and about 30 comments repeat it. **That icon came from an old test run and is not the live icon**, but viewers treat it as fact and it feeds the "Cut the AI" meme. It has to be answered: correct the record, and make sure the current art does not read as AI-made.
- **Industry framing.** Commenters put ZeptoLab in a "ruined childhood games" series with Rovio/Angry Birds, PopCap and Minion Rush ("The game is not for you or for fans. It is for shareholders.", 396 likes).
- **Lives are the most-cited mechanic** ("Cut the Rope does NOT work with limited lives considering how hard it can be. It’s like adding lives to Super Meat Boy", 1.3k likes).
- **Players are routing around the update:** old APKs on Android, CTR GOLD, the HD versions, Time Travel. The "fake Cut the Rope games" video shows clones taking advantage of the confusion.

“2026 is truly a bad year for my childhood games” — top comment, SnipeSnap video, 2.3k likes

“We, yes... WE, are switching to an outdated version of Cut the Rope” — Cut the Rope Home video, 800 likes

6. What we accept as-is, what we plan to act on, and open decisions

Cross-referenced against Slack decisions and the 4.3/4.4 scope as of 3 Nov 2026. "Accepting as-is" means a known complaint we are deliberately not changing, usually for monetization reasons.

Accepting as-is (deliberate, mostly monetization)

Complaint	Player weight	Why we keep it / note
Ad frequency (interstitials after levels and retries)	27% → 19% of reviews; #1 complaint before the update	Core revenue. Already softer in 4.x (impressions/DAU 3.11 → 2.29). Watch the effect of 4.4.0 banners.
Rewarded ads still shown after buying No Ads	Part of the 5–6% "paid but still see ads"	By design (the offer removes forced ads). **Cheap mitigation:** clearer offer copy and restore messaging ("Nothing to restore" confuses buyers).
No Ads price ($9.99)	Recurrent on iOS	Price restored 27 Oct after the 5.99 error.
4.x is easier / slightly different physics	<2%	No rebalancing during migration (decision). Low player weight.
Longer load / loading screen	<1%	Partial optimisation in 4.4.0; low player weight.
Not replying to reviews	—	No bandwidth. Consider templated replies to the top 1★ themes.

Planned / in progress

Issue	Player weight	Plan
Super Om Nom, Sweet Challenge missing	small, veterans	Shipped in 4.3.0 (26 Oct)
End of content at level 190/191 (black screen)	~1–2% of Sep–Oct reviews	4.4.0
Migration bugs (compensation gift, catch-up, double coins)	4% "lost progress"	CTRU-3197, 3204–3209 in triage for 4.4.0
Build size and load time	low	Parallel init in 4.4.0; download-on-demand only if offline risk is mitigated

Not addressed: decisions needed

Issue	Player weight	Why it matters	Option
Lives / limited attempts	14% of reviews; 11% of YouTube	Conflicts with the trial-and-error core; the most-cited "greed" signal	Test generous or no lives in early boxes, or for migrated veterans
No level select / replay	17% of reviews	Removes a habit (parents replaying with kids, replaying for stars)	Re-enable replay of completed levels
Art perceived as AI-made; old watermark-icon claim	9% of reviews; 27% of YouTube	Reputational; the claim spreads without correction	Hand-made icon refresh (art team proposal); one public clarification
Pop-up flood / forced events for migrants	5% of reviews	Every feature triggers at once on the first session	Stagger feature intros for migrated players
4.4.0 banners + loss offer	risk	Lands while the "pay-to-play" narrative is at its peak	Ship behind an A/B with a rating guardrail

7. Recommendations

- **Use the all-rater rating as the KPI and set a guardrail for 4.4.0**, for example global Play < 4.15 or iOS < 4.45 on the 30-day average. Both stores are still above 4★, so this is a reputation and retention issue more than a visibility emergency.
- **Fix the cheap, high-signal items first:** a hand-made icon, one clarification that the watermark icon was an old test, clearer No Ads copy and restore flow, and staggered pop-ups for migrants.
- **Decide on lives and level replay with data.** They are the two design changes players single out. A/B test (a) no lives for migrated veterans, or lives only after box N, and (b) replay of completed levels.

Measure retention, ad ARPDAU and the rating.

- **Sequence 4.4.0 carefully**, so banners and the loss offer do not land on top of an active "greedy" narrative.
- **Close the loop publicly once.** A short "we hear you" note (store "What’s new", pinned YouTube or community post) listing what has come back (Super Om Nom, Sweet Challenge, prices) and what is next.
- **Next data:** add Reddit and Discord, and check whether the US Play rating dip during the 1–5% stage (22 Jul–6 Aug) was linked to the rollout.